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“We’re just at the start of India’s coffee story”

Shivam Shahi, Co-Founder and COO of Blue Tokai, on India’s coffee boom, building the business, and coffee’s growing pull among young consumers

BY SIDDHARTH ZARABI & AABHA BAKAYA

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Coffee is fast becoming India’s favourite caffeine fix. Legend traces coffee’s arrival in India to a Sufi saint in the 17th century. For years after the first beans were planted in the Baba Budan Giri Hills of Chikkamagaluru, Karnataka, coffee was mostly consumed at home or in some cafés. This began to change in the 1990s with the advent of homegrown chains like Café Coffee Day. Others followed in its footsteps—with the foremost being Blue Tokai Coffee Roasters that spotted the opportunity in 2012. Today, coffee culture has spread across the country, powered by young Indians. What started as a trend is now a full-fledged business story.

Behind this rise is a mix of access and middle-class aspiration, growing

awareness about specialty coffee, more independent cafés as well as multinational chains, and a stronger brew-at-home culture. Social media has helped push coffee into the mainstream, online delivery has made it easier to order in, and wider availability of brewing equipment and quality beans has turned it into a daily ritual. The result is a generation that sees coffee as more than a beverage—shaped by purists chasing that perfect shot of caffeine.

Blue Tokai Co-Founder and COO Shivam Shahi speaks with *Business Today* Group Editor Siddharth Zarabi and Consulting Editor Aabha Bakaya on specialty coffee, shifting consumer habits, and how the pandemic triggered a surge in consumption. It also zooms in on Gen Z, which is increasingly choosing coffee over tea. Edited excerpts:

SZ: Take us back to the beginning. How did Blue Tokai start?

A: It started 13 years back. The idea was simple. India was growing good, specialty coffee, but most of it was getting exported. Domestic consumption was minimal. We went to the source. We saw ample amounts of good coffee that Indian farmers were growing, but no one was trying to create a brand around that, because everyone felt India was a tea drinking nation.